A Monster Calls

By Patrick Ness

(Pg 1-2) The monster showed up just after midnight. As they do. Conor was awake when it came. He'd had a nightmare. Well, not ***a*** nightmare. ***The*** nightmare. The one he'd been having a lot lately. The one with the darkness and the wind and the screaming.

He'd told no one about the nightmare. Not his mum, obviously, but no one else either. What happened in the nightmare was something no one else ever needed to know.

The nightmare was slipping from him, but there was something he couldn't put his finger on, something different . . . He listened, but all he could hear was the quiet house around him. Nothing.

And then something. Something he realized was the thing that had woken him. Someone was calling his name . . . ***Conor***.

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INTRODUCTION

Elizabeth Kubler Ross created a pathway to grief with her five stages: Denial, Anger, Bargaining, Depression, Acceptance. These stages are meant to allow grief to be understood, and the sufferer to let go. When Conor O'Malley finds out his mother is dying of cancer, he lives in denial and pent-up anger.

No one talks about her death -- not her, not his grandmother, not his father, and not him. Not until he is forced to face the inevitable and deal with his grief. This grief takes the form of a monster. A monster who forces him to face the truth and guides him to acceptance.

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(Pg 4) ***Conor***.

"What?" Conor said, his heart thumping, suddenly impatient for whatever was going to happen.

A cloud moved in front of the moon, and then passed, and the moon shone again. On a yew tree. Which now stood firmly in the middle of his backyard. And here was the monster. **(Pg 136)** ***The yew is a healing tree. It is the form I choose most to walk in.***

(Pg 30) "What do you want from me?"

(Pg 36) ***You will tell me the truth.***

"The truth?"

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Not just any truth. Your truth. You know that your truth, the one that you hide, Conor O'Malley, is the thing you are most afraid of. For this is why you called me.

Conor grew even more confused. "Called you? I didn't call you—

(Pg 137) ***If your mother can be healed, then the yew tree will do it.***

(Pg 141) "What's going to happen with my mum? You said you were a tree of healing. Well, I need you to heal!"

(Pg 172) ***Conor O'Malley, I did not come to hear her, I came to heal you.***

"Me? I don't need healing. My mum's the one who's..."

But he couldn't say it. Even now he couldn't say it. Even though he'd known it all along. Of course he did, no matter how much he'd wanted to believe it wasn't true, he knew. But still, he couldn't say it. Couldn't say she was--

It is time, for [your truth].

The mist surrounded them again. And once more, [he] was in the middle of the nightmare . . .

(Pg 174-175) He recognized the clearing he was in, bordered on three sides by a dark forest; the fourth side, a cliff, flying off into further blackness.

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And on the cliff's edge, his mum.

"Mum!" Conor yelled, feeling too heavy to stand. "You have to get out of here!"

"I'm fine, darling", she said, "There's nothing to worry about." She turned back to the cliff's edge, as if she'd heard something.

"No," Conor whispered to himself. He pulled himself forward some more, but she was too far, too far to reach in time, and he felt so heavy--

There was a low sound from below the cliff. A rumbling, booming noise.

Conor knew. It was too late. The real monster was coming. **(Pg 178-181)** Because with a roar, a cloud of burning darkness lifted two giant fists over the cliff top. They hovered in the air, over his mum as she tried to scramble back. But she was too weak, much too weak-

At last, Conor could run. With a shout, he broke across the clearing, running so fast he nearly toppled over, and he threw himself toward her as the dark fists pulled her over the edge. And his hands caught hers.

"Help me, Conor! Don't let go!" his mum yelled.

"I won't! I promise!'

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The nightmare monster pulled harder, its fists straining around his mother's body. And she began to slip from Conor's grasp.

"No!" he called.

His mum screamed in terror. "Please, Conor! Hold on to me!"

[But even as she said this, her hands] were slipping from his grasp, and she was getting heavier and heavier; the nightmare monster pulling harder and harder. He fell forward onto his chest from the weight of her. She screamed again.

"Please!" Conor whispered to himself. "*Please!*"

"NO!" Conor screamed. And his mother fell.

And here, he heard the yew tree say, ***is the truth of Conor O'Malley.*** **(Pg 185-189)** ***You let her go.***

"I didn't let her go! She fell!" Conor shouted.

You must tell the truth or you will never leave this nightmare. You will be trapped here alone for the rest of your life.

"I don't know what you mean!" Conor yelled desperately trying to fight the monster's urging.

You do know, it said, low and threatening.

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And there was a sudden quiet. Because yes, Conor knew. The truth. The real truth from the nightmare.

"Please don't make me, please don't make me say it."

You let her go. You could have held on for longer, but you loosened your grip. You wanted her her to go.

"NO!"

You must speak the truth, Conor O'Malley. Say it. You must.

"I can't."

You let her go. Why? Tell me WHY! Before it's too late!

A moan started in his throat, a moan that rose into a cry and then a loud wordless yell and he opened his mouth. And he spoke the truth.

"I can't stand it anymore!" He cried out. "I can't stand knowing that she'll go! I just want it to be over! I want it to be finished! I've known forever that she wasn't going to make it. And I started to think how much I wanted it to be over. How I couldn't stand the waiting anymore. I couldn't stand how alone it made me feel."

He began to cry now, more than he thought he'd ever done. More than when he found out his mum was ill.

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(Pg 203) He wanted to ask the monster what was going to happen then, but he didn't dare.

Because he knew.

[And then they were in his mother's hospital room] **(Pg 202)** The monster's hands gently but firmly guided him toward [her]. **(Pg 203-205)** Conor looked down at [her], and he took his mother's hand.

She opened her eyes, briefly, catching him there. Then she closed them again.

But she'd seen him. And he knew ***it*** was here. He knew there really was no going back. That ***it*** was going to happen. And he knew he was going to get through it. And an at last, he spoke the final and total truth . . .

"I don't want you to go," He said, the tears dropping from his eyes slowly at first, then spilling like a river.

"I know my love," His mother said in her heavy voice. "I know."

He could feel the monster, holding him up and letting him stand there.

"I don't want you to go," he said again.

And that was all he needed to say. He leaned forward on her bed and put his arms around her. Holding her. He

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knew it would come. The moment she would slip from his grasp, no matter how tightly he held on.

But not this moment, the monster whispered, still close. ***Not just yet.***

Conor held tightly onto to his mother. And by doing so, he could finally let her go.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

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